



Scoping for Success

Game Design on a Deadline

2026



Nice to meet you!



Michael Smilovitch

Senior Game Design Consultant



Stuff I've worked on



Game
Developer



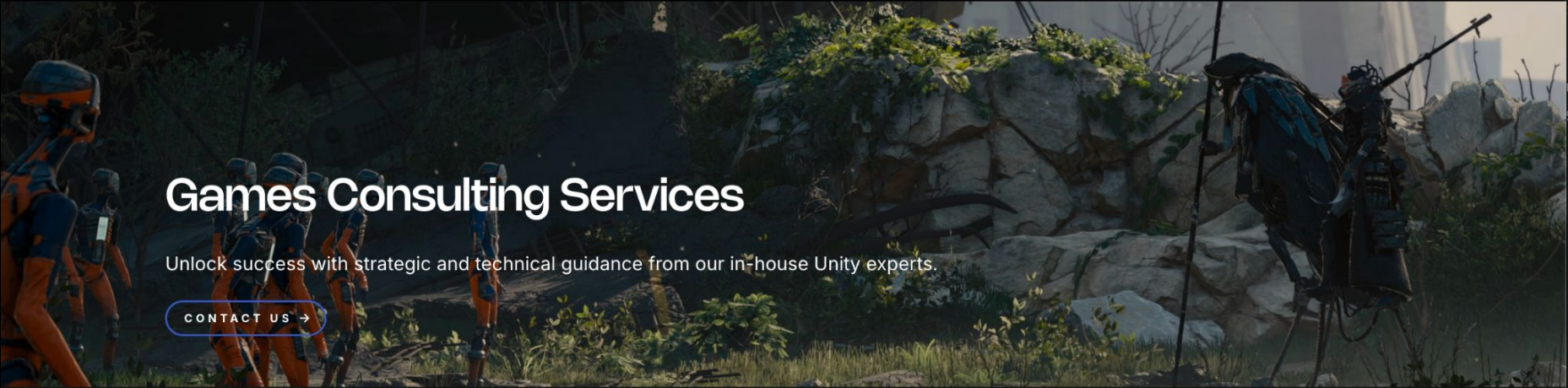
Lead
Game Designer



Writer



Concept &
Prototyping



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Overview

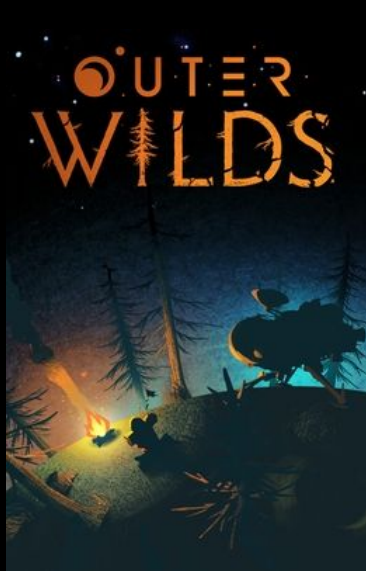
- Jam goals
- Game jam phases
 - Initial idea
 - Scoping
 - Execution
 - Polish
- Q&A / Discussion





Jam goals









Learning

"I want to make something leveraging this specific tool/asset/feature as a way to learn it"

Execution

"I want to make the best game possible within the jam's timeframe"

Don't assume! All reasons for participating are valid, just communicate your expectations with your team.



Shift your mindset

- You have 48 hrs to make **a game**
- This is not enough time so you'll have to
 - *scope strategically*
 - *find the fun quickly*
 - *cut & compromise*



**Perfect is the enemy of
good**



“Le mieux est l’ennemi du bien”

— Voltaire



Initial idea





**There's a lot
you can
decide before
the theme is
released**





**There's a lot
you can
decide before
the theme is
released**

- Team
- Genre
- Tools
- Priorities
- Expectations
- Philosophy
- Full game idea!



Elevator pitch



Elevator pitch





Elevator pitch

Simple is good

- **Can be explained in 10 seconds**
- **Can be outlined in 1-2 sentences (140 characters)**
- **Can be achieved in the timeframe**

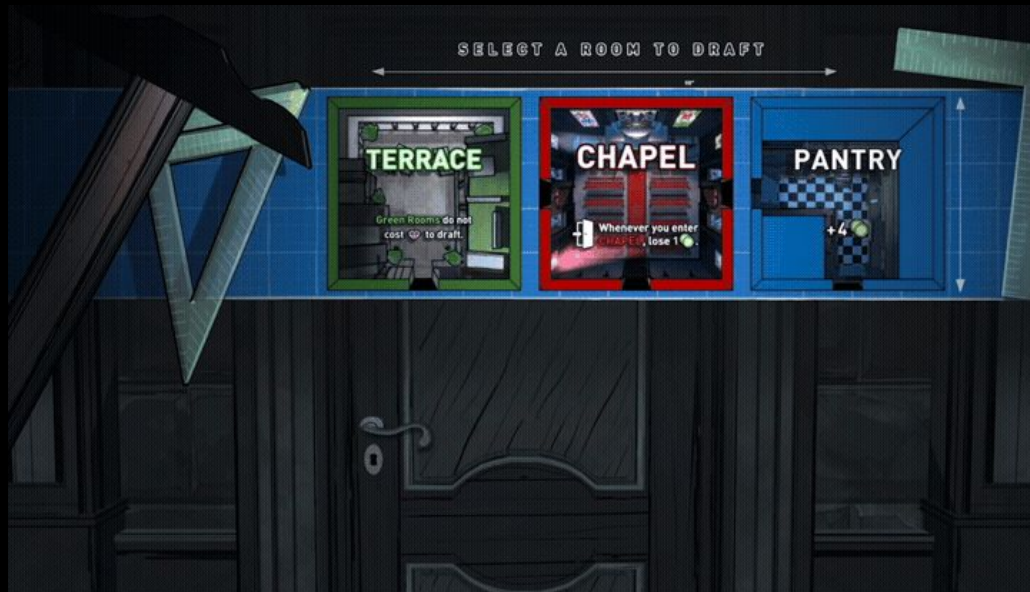


This + that

- Everything is a remix, don't worry about taking inspiration from touchpoints old and new**



- For example: the room selection mechanic from Blue Prince





Do:

- **Brainstorm, consider a few options**
- **Write up early ideas with pros and cons**
- **Compromise + Yes &**
- **Get to prototyping ASAP**

Don't:

- **Get too bogged down in details before they exist**
- **Spend too long debating ideas**
- **Make things you won't use**



Execution > Ideas



Execution → Ideas



Scoping





**There's a lot
you can
decide before
the jam starts**





**There's a lot
you can
decide before
the jam starts**

- Schedule
- Responsibilities
- Work blocks
- Breaks
- Sleep goals

Scheduling

- There is no "right" amount of time to spend
- Scope according capacity
- Conservative scoping → comfortable jam



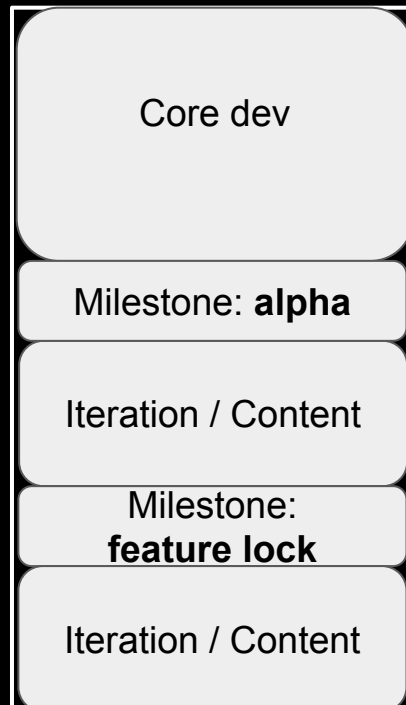


Example 48hr Jam Schedule

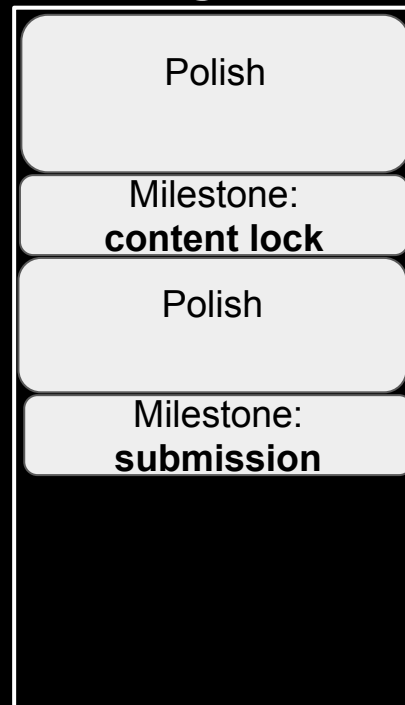
Day 1



Day 2



Day 3





Expect the unexpected

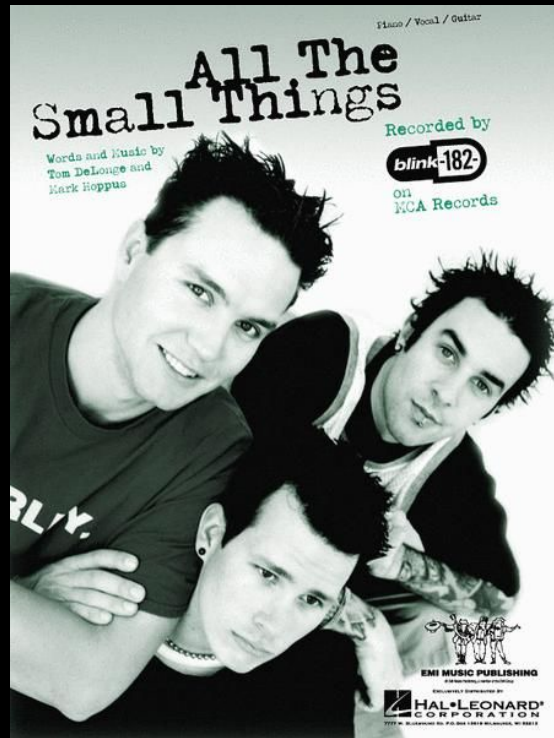


- Start by finding the fun
- To do this, you need something playable
- If the first playable isn't fun, top priority is making it fun ASAP
- Once a prototype is "good enough", lock the idea in



The small things add up

- Onboarding/tutorial
- Menus
- Settings
- Audio (a little bit goes a long way)





Scope defensively

- Play to the team's strengths!
- Avoid doing complex overly ambitious things for the first time if you haven't clearly established exploration as a goal of the jam
- Unknowns = potential points of failure (nothing wrong with it, but depends on the goal! Learn vs. make a game)



Time

- Goal: make a game
- Judges will likely play for a few minutes (note: GGJ is not a contest)
- Nobody will have patience for unclear games
- First 2 minutes are the most important
- Aim for 5-10 minutes of polished content





Execution





**There's a lot
you can do
before the jam
starts**





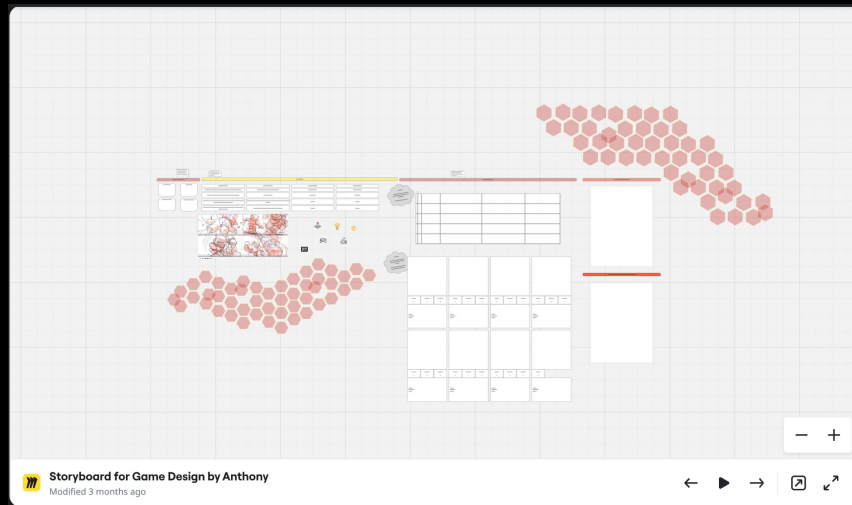
**There's a lot
you can do
before the jam
starts**

- Team repo
- Productivity tools
- Work environment
- Assets
- Tutorials
- Documentation
- Research (gaming)

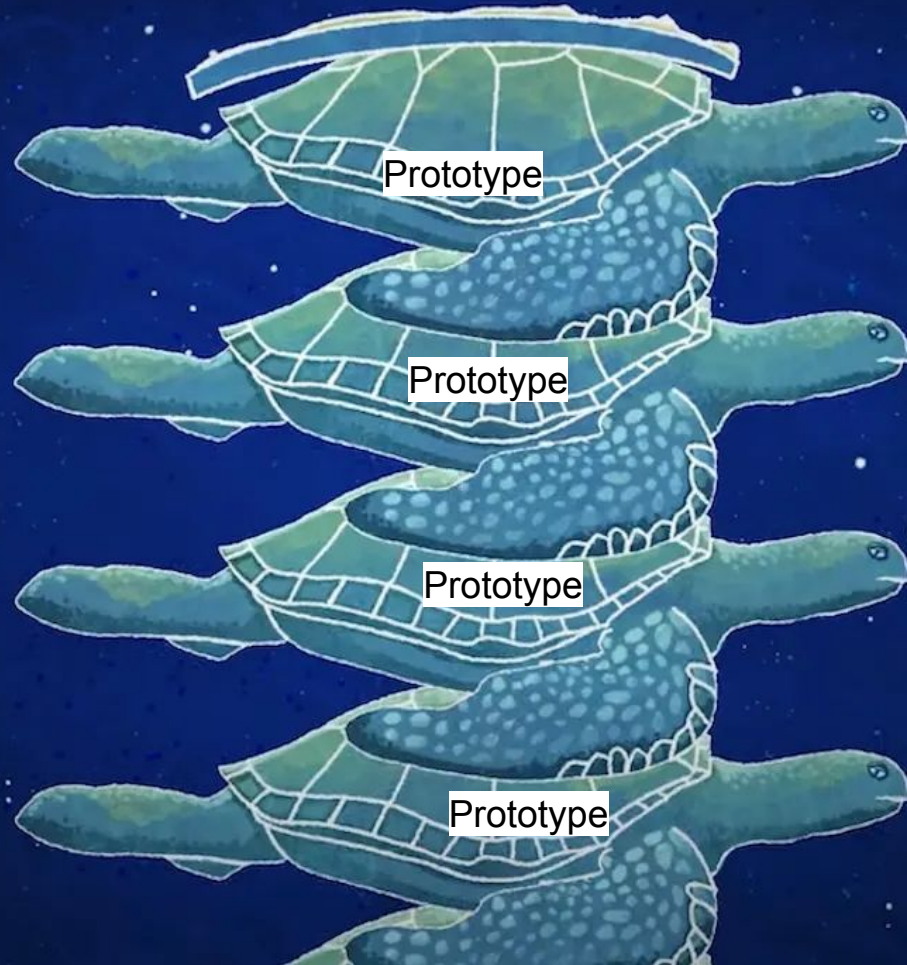


Communication

- Communicate ruthlessly! Work publicly, post about your progress and keep everyone in the loop
- Set check-in times and agree on priorities



- Shared creative space
- Built-in kanban
- Prevent miscommunication





Prototypes all the way down

- A jam game itself is sort of a prototype
- Keep in mind that your first step is making a prototype of a prototype, so focus on those **core questions** and remember it's not that serious



Priorities

- Focus on **one** core mechanic or concept and get that actually feeling good
 - NOT worried about art, menus, UI at first
- **Feel > content** at this point
 - Would sooner add some sound and juice
- Goal: *find the fun day 1*



Content

- Don't forget the content!
- Classic to spend most of the time on systems and then have one sandbox area or only a few levels
- Leave time to make levels so the game has a beginning/middle/end



Finish early

- If you're content locked early, you can add *JUICE*



Renaud Forestié
@reuno

Best Practices for
Fast Game Design
in Unity

unity
Unite
Los Angeles
2018





Playtests

- Playtest throughout, regularly putting the game in front of people
- Once menus + onboarding are in, assess legibility and iterate based on feedback!





Polish





**You can't
polish ahead
of time, can
you?**





**You *can*
prepare for
the polish
phase by
actually being
on schedule**





Don't let polish be a luxury!

- It WILL be tempting to keep adding until the last minute, but this will hurt the final quality of the game!
- Plan for more polish time than you need, so when you inevitably sacrifice some of it, you'll still have some time leftover



The juice is worth the squeeze

- Add juice to interactions
- Implement user feedback
- Look for quick wins



Renaud Forestié
@reuno

Best Practices for
Fast Game Design
in Unity



Best Practices for Fast Game Design in Unity

Unity
Unite
Los Angeles
2018



In summary

- There are no rules just communicate expectations to yourself and others
- Remember the goal, whatever it is (make a game, learn a tool)
- Scope way way down, a short polished game is better than an unfinished opus



Tools





Free stuff!

Free Resources

Useful Web Resources:

Upload your Games etc.

Cross-Platform (Web or Desktop)

<https://itch.io/>
<https://gamejolt.com/>

Desktop Only

<https://www.indiedb.com/>

Web Only

<https://www.newgrounds.com/>
<https://www.kongregate.com/>

Game Jam Websites

<https://djam.com/>

Online Game Services API

<https://devloggames.com/en-US/services>
<https://gamejolt.com/game-spldoc>
<https://devloggames.com/en-US/services>
<https://www.newgrounds.com/wiki/crate-resources/flash-api>

Sound Resources

<https://sonosis.com/gameaudiologs>
<http://soundimage.org/>
<http://www.freesound.org/>
<http://soundible.com/>
<http://www.flashkit.com/soundfx/>

Music Resources

<https://compotest.filmusic.io/>
<https://www.berasound.com/>
<https://soundimage.org/>
<https://antismusic.blogspot.com/> (https://www.reddit.com/r/gamedev/comments/72yapn/i_have_released_my_1393_instrumental_songs_free/)
<https://www.newgrounds.com/audio/>
<https://itch.io/soundtracks>
<http://d4g.com/stor/>
<https://freemusicarchive.org/>
<https://audionautix.com/>
<http://tabletopaudio.com/>
<http://www.flashkit.com/loops/>

Find more in this blog post <https://felgo.com/game-resources/free-music-for-games>

Art Resources

<https://kenney.nl/assets>
<https://itch.io/game-assets/>
<http://www.openpixelproject.com/>
<https://opengameart.org/>
<https://www.gameart2d.com/freebies.html>
<http://game-icons.net/>
<https://www.newgrounds.com/art>
<https://www.freepik.com/>
<https://crateboy.itch.io/crateboy-2007-2014>
http://www.dumbmanex.com/bynd_freestuff.html
<http://untamed.wild-refuge.net/tpgvp.php>

Visual Novel characters:

<http://tokudaya.net/sozai-otoko1.html>
<http://tokudaya.net/sozai-onna1.html>

Images/Photos Resources

<https://www.pexels.com/>
<https://www.photosforwork.com/>

Textures Resources

<https://cc0textures.com/>
<https://www.sharetextures.com/>
<https://3dtextures.me/>
<https://soundimage.org/> (TXR-*)
<http://texturelib.com/>
<https://freestocktextures.com/>
<https://www.toplat.com/designers/subtlepatterns/>

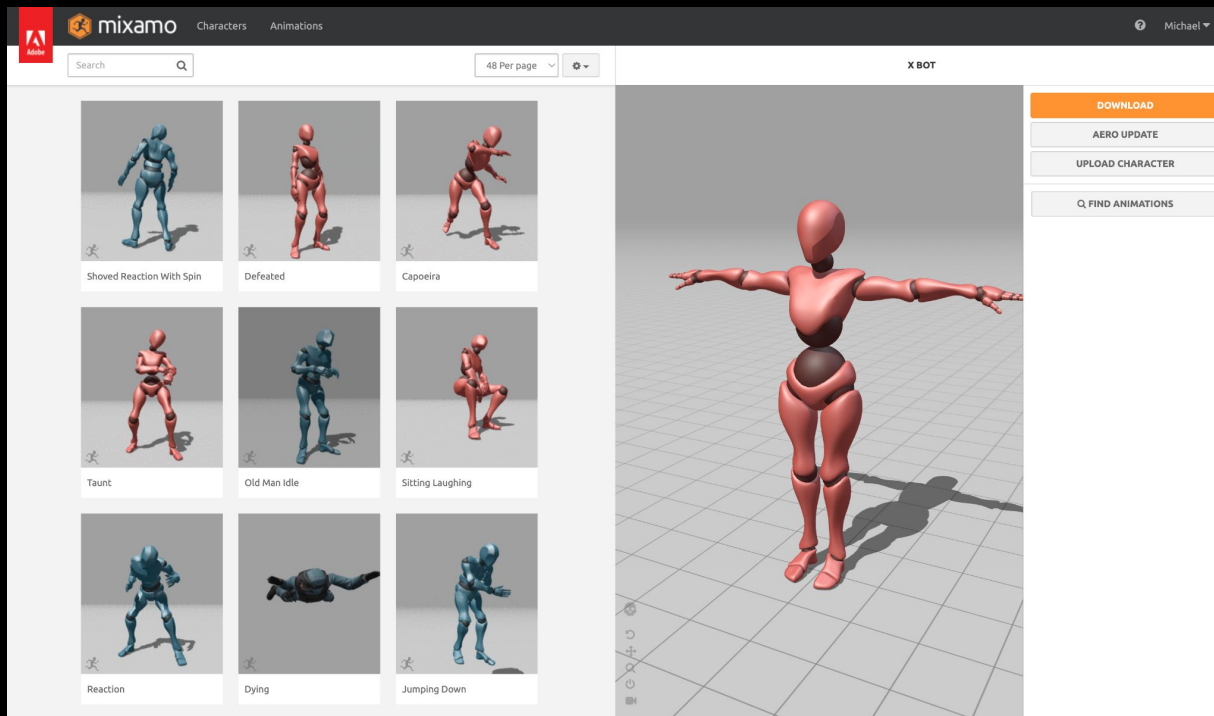
3D Objects Resources

<http://quaternius.com/assets.html> (https://www.reddit.com/r/gamedev/comments/772z0w/free_lowpoly_furniture/)
<https://nasa3d.arc.nasa.gov/>
<https://www.3dmodelscc0.com/>
<https://www.gamessetsgarden.com/>
<https://resources.blogscopia.com/category/models/>
<https://www.blender-models.com/>
http://www.esi-ucim.es/museg/index_en.html
<https://free3d.com/>
<https://archive3d.net/>
<http://www.3dmodelfree.com/>
<https://poly.pizza>

<https://github.com/kobitoko/Game-Jam-Tools-Resources>



Free stuff!

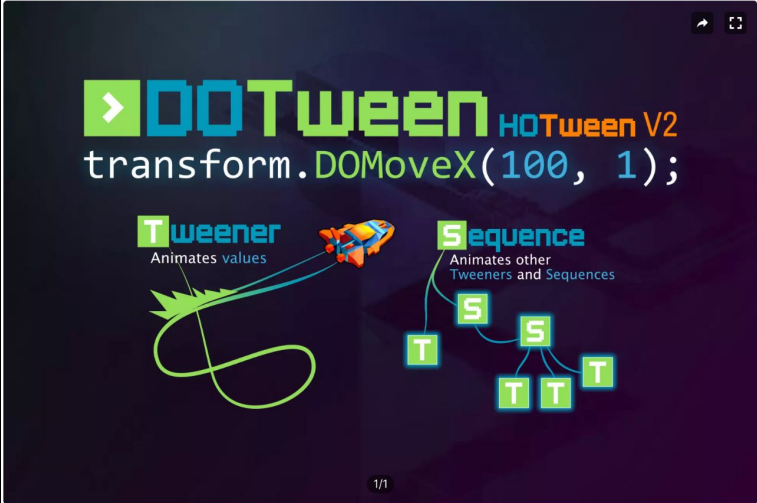


Mixamo for 3d animations



Free stuff!

Home > Tools > Animation > DOTween (HOTween v2)



The screenshot shows the DOTween (HOTween v2) asset page on the Unity Asset Store. The main visual is a dark blue background with the DOTween logo in green and orange, followed by 'HOTween V2' in orange. Below the logo is the code snippet `transform.DOMoveX(100, 1);`. To the left, a 'Tween' icon is shown with a green line animating a rocket. To the right, a 'Sequence' icon is shown with a tree diagram of 'S' (Sequence) and 'T' (Tween) blocks. The right sidebar contains the asset details: 'DOTween (HOTween v2)' by 'Demigiant', a 5-star rating (1335 reviews), and 14514 likes. It is marked as 'FREE' and has 4550 views in the past week. A blue 'Add to My Assets' button is present. Below this, a table lists the license agreement, type, file size, version, release date, and support link.

DOTween (HOTween v2)
Demigiant ★★★★★ (1335) | ❤️ (14514)

FREE

👁 4550 views in the past week

[Add to My Assets](#)

License agreement	Standard Unity Asset Store EULA
License type	Extension Asset
File size	235.6 KB
Latest version	1.2.790
Latest release date	Dec 8, 2025
Original Unity version	2020.3.0
Support	Visit site

Move stuff around!



Thank you

2026

Happy jamming!



Q&A / Discussion





Tips and tricks?

Recommendations
for cool tools?

Fun ideas?



Resources



Image resources

→ [Stock image library](#)

→ [Event image library](#)

→ [Support request](#)

→ Free stock photos - [Unsplash](#)

→ Infographics (coming soon)



Icons

CORE





Icons

AV



COMMUNICATION



DEVICE





Icons

NOTIFICATION



SOCIAL

